

Nearly 67.3 percent of the total population were Buddhists, while Hindus formed the second largest religious group with 2.2 million or 17.6 percent of the total population. Muslims and Roman Catholics were equal in number, each group consisting of approximately 900,000 or 7.1 percent of the total population. If Roman Catholics and Christians of all other denominations are considered as one group - Christians - nearly one million persons or 8 percent of the population were Christians and they formed the third largest religious group. All the other religious groups and the free thinkers were included in the category of "Others" which was negligible, being only 0.1 percent of the total population.

6.9 Changes in the distribution of Religious groups : Though the number of adherents of each religion has been increasing in absolute numbers, only Buddhism has grown in proportions. Upto 1911 almost all the religious groups had maintained their proportionate share in the total population. In 1921 the proportion of Buddhists increased to 61.6 from 60.3 percent in 1911 and that of Hindus declined to 21.8 percent from 22.9 percent. This decline corresponds to a decline in proportions of the Tamils in 1921 (see Table 6.9).

Since 1946 Buddhism has forged ahead of Hinduism and Christianity. The percentage of Buddhists which was 64.5 percent in 1946 had risen to 67.3 percent in 1971, whereas during the same period the percentage of the Hindus had declined from 19.8 percent in 1946 to 17.6 percent and that of Christians from 9.1 percent to 7.9 percent.

Apart from Buddhism the only religion which had grown in proportion is Islam. The proportion of Muslims increased from 6.6 percent in 1946 to 7.1 percent in 1971. The proportional growth of Buddhism and the decline in Christianity may be owing to the "resurgence of nationalism" with the gaining of independence in 1948. The decline in the proportion of Hindus was mainly due to the decline in the numbers of the Indian immigrants. During the period 1946 to 1971 the growth of the Muslims was mainly a result of the growth in numbers of Sri Lanka Moors.

TABLE 6.10 : PERCENTAGE CHANGES IN RELIGION AND RACE

Religion & Race	1881-1911	1911-1946	1946-1971
Buddhists	45.70	73.56	98.77
Sinhalese	47.0	70.1	97.6
Hindus	58.07	40.71	69.56
Tamils	54.1	59.1	71.1
Muslims	43.48	53.91	106.60
Moors	44.5	53.5	109.0
Christians	52.68	47.41	66.50

Table 6.10 indicates the percentage growth of the religions and corresponding ethnic groups during the three periods of 1881-1911, 1911-1946 & 1946-1971. It is evident from the Table that the growth of each religious group is parallel to that of the corresponding ethnic group.

6.10 Distribution of Religious Groups by Districts : Percentage distribution of each religion among the 22 districts is given in the Table 6.11.